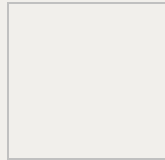


ON TECHNIQUE

Ondes Martenot

Messiaen was an important pioneer of the ondes Martenot (Martenot “waves”)—an early electronic instrument invented in 1928 by Maurice Martenot, a former radio telegrapher and cellist, who was inspired by the radio oscillators that were used by the army. Messiaen first used the instrument’s strange, futuristic, wavering sound (which resembles the theremin) in a work commissioned for the World Fair in 1937. His future sister-in-law, Jeanne Loriod, was a highly accomplished performer on the unusual instrument.



ONDES MARTENOT, INVENTED BY MAURICE MARTENOT IN 1928

Messiaen was born in the French city of Avignon on December 10, 1908, and was baptized on Christmas Day. Both his parents were highly cultivated. His father, Pierre, was an English teacher and translator of some of Shakespeare’s plays, but Olivier was closer to his mother, Cécile Sauvage, a distinguished poet. While pregnant, she wrote a collection of poems for her unborn child: *L’Ame en bourgeon* (The Budding Soul). Messiaen treasured them, believing some lines to be prophetic, such as: “I suffer from an unknown, distant music” and “All the Orient is singing here within me, with its blue birds.”